DROWNED IN SOUND

# BRAND KIT

*Drowned in Sound and SHOWNOTES. Everything we know about how both brands look, sound and behave, written for the web designer.*

SHOWNOTES

2 November 2026. Draft for review by Sean Adams.

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## How to read it

Two brands share one family look. DiS is the publication, newsletter and podcast network. SHOWNOTES is the printed magazine and its stockist map. Where a rule differs between them, the page says so.

Where something is a guess, or hasn't been confirmed, it says so in plain words.

*The shared folder next to this PDF has the logos, tokens.css, brand.json and the safe zone diagram. Licensed fonts are not in it, on purpose. See page 9.*

# Drowned in Sound

Started 1998 as a website recommending music. Now a non-profit publication: a weekly newsletter, a podcast network and a community forum. Supports independent artists and brands, especially in the UK and Ireland.

It follows threads from music to systemic questions: fairness in the industry (pay, gender representation, access), platform power, and how music fans can use their collective power. It is a publication, not an activist organisation.

Shows: The DiS Podcast, Sounds Like Change, How Music Can Save The World. Related: The Sounding (growth consultancy and media house), Association of Music Editors, Neptune Prize.

drownedinsound.org | community.drownedinsound.com | thesounding.org

# SHOWNOTES

The printed magazine (Issue 1 is 64 pages) and its stockist map of about 500 venues across the UK, where copies are picked up. Built to be loud on paper and plain on screen: big flat shapes, hot pink and near-black, a serif with real contrast.

Map: a stockist map of the venues is on the SHOWNOTES site.

*The animating idea behind both: culture and working people are upstream from billionaires, and music fans are an untapped political force. Hope over guilt. Another world is possible.*

# How we write

Like someone explaining something they care about at a pub, not performing on a stage. Thinks out loud, credits other people, names names, and ends with a real question or a plain sign-off, never a slogan.

People first, not concepts. Specific and recent over name-dropping. Facts checked, sources cited. Hope over guilt. Dry humour, tucked into brackets.

Preferred word for people who campaign: campaigner (not activist). Not: content creator.

# Never

Em-dashes. Use a comma or hyphen.

PR voice: "we're thrilled", "exciting news", "stay tuned", "join the conversation", "a game-changer".

Corporate language: "stakeholder ecosystem", "leveraging", "synergy", "catalysing change".

"At DiS, we believe...". Manifesto slogans and catchphrases.

Emojis in body text. Bullet lists and bold text in social copy.

## 2 LOGOS: DROWNED IN SOUND

Three main versions, transparent background, 4500 x 4500 px PNG. On black use the pink one.




**Pink on black (default)**




**Off-white on pink or photographs**




**Black on light backgrounds**

*Also supplied (logos/DiS other marks): the same logo on black, The DiS Podcast logo, a YouTube banner, and The Sounding.*







*Podcast and The Sounding marks come with a black background.*




**On black: pink**




**On pink: black**




**On photos: off-white**

SHOWNOTES logo: a wide wordmark, so give it width: 240 to 300 px on a 1080 px asset. Keep clear space around it of at least the height of the "O" circle on every side. Pink next to anything pink on screen: use the logo pink #E95470.

## Rules for every logo

Never stretch, recolour, outline or add shadow, glow or gradient.

Place on black, pink, paper or a photograph with enough contrast.

On video: small, top right, about 256 px tall on a 1080 x 1920 canvas, aligned to the right margin. Open and close each video with the logo.

Druk, the font in the logo artwork, is for the logo only. Never set live text in it on video.

*Flat colour only. Hot pink and near-black do most of the work, paper white for reading.*

### Pink (logo)

#E95470
RGB 233, 84, 112

Anything next to the logo on screen. Headlines, labels, emphasis, one word of a subtitle.

### Pink (print)

#EE5D75
RGB 238, 93, 117

Magazine only. Close to logo pink; do not mix next to the logo on screen.

### Black

#121211
RGB 18, 18, 17

Page fills, large shapes, subtitle strips.

### Ink

#010204
RGB 1, 2, 4

Text on white and on pink.

### Paper

#F1E8F3
RGB 241, 232, 243

Body text on black or pink. A very slightly lilac off-white.

### White

#FFFFFF
RGB 255, 255, 255

Cut-out shapes, credits on dark.

### Logo off-white

#F9FDF4
RGB 249, 253, 244

The off-white inside the logo files.

## Contrast checks (WCAG: 4.5 for body text, 3 for large text)

Aa Rou

Paper on black
**15.7:1 pass**

Aa Rou

Pink on black
**5.3:1 pass**

Aa Rou

Ink on pink
**5.9:1 pass**

Aa Rou

Black on pink
**5.3:1 pass**

Aa Rou

Ink on white
**20.8:1 pass**

Aa Rou

Pink on white
**3.5:1 large text only**

Aa Rou

Paper on pink
**2.9:1 FAIL**

# Rules

Pairings that work: pink on black, black on pink, paper on black, ink on white. Pink text on white only for small italic credits (it does not pass for body text).

Pink is for what should be read first: numbers, a name, one word. Use it sparingly so it keeps its punch.

Never grey text on a dark background. If you want a second level, change size or weight, not colour.

No gradients, drop shadows or glows. (The soft glow on map pins is a screen-only choice on the map.)

# Older DiS rules, being retired

Instagram carousels used: #0A0A0A background, #FF2E95 pink, #FFFFFF text, Francois One headlines in capitals, Cardo body, 1080 x 1350.

The new look (29 October 2026) replaces them with the palette on the previous page and the type on the next. Use the new look for anything new. Old carousels need updating, not copying.

**#0A0A0A (old)**

**#FF2E95 (old)**

*Licensed fonts are not in the shared folder. See type/FONTS.md and the web setup below.*

## SHOWNOTES

Titles: Druk XX Cond Super

Body: Abril Text (Regular, Italic)

Pink italic for credits, asides, details

Labels and numbers: Flash SB / LTC Flash

Stand-ins: Abril Fatface, Playfair Display

## DiS (new look)

Logo only: Druk

Video headlines: Alternate Gothic No2, capitals

Subtitles and body: Abril Text, Bold for subtitles

Never live text in Druk (hard to read small)

## DiS (old, retiring)

Headlines: Francois One, capitals

Body: Cardo

Minimum body size 16 px, labels 14 px

### Web delivery that already works on the map site

Druk: self-hosted woff2 on the live site (designer confirmed a web licence). Abril Text and LTC Flash: Adobe Fonts web project "SHOWNOTES map", https://use.typekit.net/ulr4flt.css. Fallback for Druk: League Gothic Condensed.

### Specimen (Playfair Display, the free stand-in for Abril Text)

**Rou Reynolds on the year it fell apart**

*Italic for credits and asides.*

## Grid

6 columns. 60 px margins and 24 px gutters on a 1080 px asset (scale proportionally for web). Sizes in multiples of 8. Everything aligns to column 1 at the left. One headline per layout.



*Pink bands = the six columns. Margin 60, gutter 24 (at 1080 wide).*

## Shapes

Flat, one colour, and they run off the page edge. They never contain text and never have gradients or shadows. They sit behind or beside the layout, not around the words.



**Circle** **Wedge** **Starburst** **Circle run**

*Labels such as FEATURE or OPINION sit inside a tilted white wedge in the magazine. On screen, set labels as plain text on the background. Do not recreate the tilted tags.*

## Feed card

1080 x 1440 (3:4), exported at 2160 x 2880. Black background, pink logo top left, 60 px margins. One big headline in pink, one line of support in paper. Pink for what should be read first. A plain closing line, never a slogan.

## Other formats

Story or Reel: 1080 x 1920 (9:16).
Old DiS carousels: 1080 x 1350 (4:5), 12 slides at most.
Carousel data slides: let the numbers dominate.
Never design at one size and scale down.




## Map card anatomy, top to bottom

Pink logo, top left.
City name, big, pink.
One italic line under it: the venue count, in paper.
The map: roads and rivers in dim pink, numbered pink circles with a black ring.
Two columns of numbered venue names, numbers pink, names paper.
About 30 venues per card. London (111 venues) is a six-slide carousel.




*Reels safe zone, 1080 x 1920 (shaded = keep clear)*

## Overlays

Keep clear: 220 px top, 450 px bottom, 35 px sides. A column of buttons sits bottom right, 100 px wide from about 750 px up, so text stops 135 px from the right edge.

Headline: Alternate Gothic No2, capitals, 232 px (176 px with a guest line), line height 88%, up to four lines, last word may be pink. Guest line 80 px pink.

Subtitles: Abril Text Bold 72 px, paper on one continuous black strip, no gaps, one pink word allowed. None on 16:9.

Titles stay up 5 seconds or more. No end-card box and no "link in bio"; the caption carries the link.

## Grade

Flat, richer film colour on both cameras. Fuji camera: LUT "DiS Eterna - Fuji Richer colour". iPhone wide shot: "DiS Eterna - iPhone matched" (skin a touch less red). The LUT files are in the brand kit folder on Sean's Mac.

## Accessibility

Body text 16 px or larger. Contrast 4.5:1 or better for body text. Never grey text on dark. No information carried by colour alone. Respect reduced motion. Test at 400 px wide.

## Behaviour

Flat colour, no gradients or shadows, except the map pin glow, which is map-only. Shapes decorative, text never inside a shape. Keep layouts left-aligned to one column edge. Big type, short lines.

## tokens.css (also in the folder)

```
--pink: #E95470;
--pink-print: #EE5D75;  /* print only */
--black: #121211;
--ink: #010204;
--paper: #F1E8F3;
--white: #FFFFFF;
--logo-white: #F9FDF4;

--grid-columns: 6;
--margin: 60px;  --gutter: 24px;
--step: 8px;  --min-body: 16px;
```

*Existing live pieces to match: the SHOWNOTES stockist map, its Druk and Adobe Fonts setup, and the SHOWNOTES map cards.*

## Do

Black backgrounds, pink for emphasis, paper for reading.

One big headline, one supporting line.

Name real people, places and records. Short sentences.

Align everything to one left edge. Sizes in multiples of 8.

Check contrast every time.

Say what is not known yet, in plain words.

## Don't

Put text inside a shape or on a tilted shape.

Use gradients, shadows, glows or outlines.

Use grey text on dark backgrounds.

Set live text in Druk.

Use em-dashes, "we're thrilled", "exciting news" or "stay tuned".

Show copy numbers, emails or phone numbers from the planner anywhere public.